Again, the increased parent involvement and awareness show up in increased motivation and production in the classroom.

5. **Take risks.** Try something new. Go to a conference, and then try the latest ideas or techniques in your classroom. Students change every year. There are always improvements and new discoveries in the field. Make it your job to keep up with the changes and share them with your students. You will have fun, the students will have fun, and you will never tire of teaching your subject.

What Is a Good Teacher?

Carey Jenkins
Paterson, New Jersey

My teaching philosophy and practices evolved out of my experiences as a poor African American student growing up in rural Mississippi, where I attended elementary and high school. After high school, I attended California State University and graduated with a degree in business. I had a very successful business career with General Foods and Philip Morris Corporation. When I made the decision to leave industry and go into education, I wanted to teach and work in an inner-city environment with students who were from a socioeconomic background similar to mine. For me, the ideal place was the Paterson School District in Paterson, New Jersey, because I wanted to work with inner-city students who needed to be encouraged. I have received numerous local and national awards for my practices and results in the classroom. Among the awards I have received that are best known are the Reader's Digest American Hero in Education Award, received in 1998, and the New Jersey Pride Award in Education, received in 1999. Teachers must employ many basic and creative practices in the classroom to teach and to simultaneously instill in the minds of inner-city students the message that you are conveying the desire to learn.

My purpose here is to share with readers the seven approaches or practices that have always worked for me. The practices are as follows:

- A good teacher has to be a good salesman.
- A good teacher takes the child wherever he or she is and moves forward.
- A good teacher is a risk taker and disciplines with "tough love."
- A good teacher must motivate and build up the student's self-esteem.
- A good teacher must take a holistic approach in dealing with students.
- A good teacher must be able to control his or her students using the "tough love" approach.
- A good teacher must teach students the importance of education.

Selling Your Subject

A good teacher has to be a good salesman. If you can't sell, you can't teach. This philosophy applies to any classroom teacher in America, particularly in an inner-city environment. I have had many teachers in my life who have stood in front of the class and put me to sleep. The assumption teachers make when they stand in front of their class is that students know why they need that subject and why they come to school in the first place. These assumptions are totally false.

I started my business career after college as a sales representative for General Foods Corporation. When we went out to call on buyers each day, we did not make sales just by talking about our products. We had to talk about how the products we were selling would help the store. We had to explain how our products would make money for that store. Because we were often fighting competition, it was not always easy. However, we were getting paid to convince the buyers that they needed our products and that our products would generate a certain

volume of business. That's what we called good salesmanship, and that is precisely what has to take place in the classroom. The math teacher must convince the students that they need math, and teachers of other subjects must do the same thing. If this selling process does not take place in the classroom, not a great deal of learning is going to take place. Clearly, this is what must take place in the inner-city classrooms across America.

Take the Child Wherever He or She Is and Move Forward

It was frustrating in the beginning because there were students who entered my class with different ability levels. Some students were at or above grade level, whereas others hardly knew what was going on. There were other students in my class who were highly motivated and others who did not know why they were in the class.

Many teachers placed in this situation start placing blame and making excuses for their anticipated failure by saying the following: These kids will never learn because they are from the projects, they come from deprived homes, or they were not adequately prepared in grammar school. Once you start doing that, you've lost the battle.

A teacher must take each student where he or she is and move forward. As a matter of practice, I start each class with a review of the material to be covered, followed by a pretest. By doing so, I know where each student is and can now proceed to teach. The teaching process takes place on a general level that is designed to reach the majority of the students. Small clusters of students who fall in front or behind the group are addressed individually. No one is embarrassed, and no one is singled out; it works each and every time.

A Good Teacher Is a Risk Taker

A good teacher will do anything that works to get the message to the students. I have known many teachers who use the same old lesson plans to teach the same subject year after year. If one approach does not work in a classroom, try another. A good teacher will experi-

ment, try things, take chances, and do whatever it takes to give students good classroom experiences. In order to be effective in the classroom, a good teacher has to be a risk taker. To be effective, you must stick your neck out every day for your teaching philosophy and practices.

A Good Teacher Helps Students Believe in Themselves

In order to get African American and Latino youths to achieve, you must get them to believe in themselves. On a daily basis, African American and Latino youths are told that they are nothing and that they are nobodies in the home, school, and community. It is the first obstacle the classroom teacher must overcome if inner-city youths are to become good students.

Teaching them about their history can help African American and Latino students with their self-esteem. First, it should be noted that every group has its heroes, inventors, and achievers. Whether a teacher is teaching math, history, or science, approximately 10 to 15 minutes each period must be set aside to inspire, encourage, and motivate inner-city students. The class may be asked to research a prominent historical figure so that person can be discussed in class, or the teacher may simply select a prominent African American or Latino personality of the past or present and discuss his or her accomplishment with the students. This is one of several ways to get these students to feel good about themselves, which is the first step to instilling in them a desire to learn.

The majority of my students always did well because I told them they could do well. I told them they could do anything they wanted to do. I said this over and over again like a "broken record" every day. By the time they graduated, they believed it. What we are talking about again here is salesmanship. Our students (inner-city) suffer from low self-esteem. They tend not to believe in themselves because everyone beats them down. Once that confidence level is built up, the students are ready to learn.

A Good Teacher Deals With the Whole Child

When a teacher stands in front of an inner-city class, ready to teach, he or she is facing students with a variety of problems. Some of their problems are sufficiently serious that they take precedence over the subject the teacher would like to teach. An example of these problems may be physical, psychological, or sexual abuse. Other problems may be related to poverty, such as not having enough food, living in inadequate housing (crowded or not enough heat), or facing an eviction notice because of unpaid rent. These are everyday problems many of our students are dealing with. A good teacher will also make it a practice to get to know the parents of the students. It is not necessary to wait until Back-to-School Night to accomplish this. A phone call to the home or a note inviting parents into the school to visit the teacher or classroom of their sons and daughters is sufficient. Getting to know the parents accomplishes many things, two of which I will mention: (a) It enables you to understand the child better, and (b) the parent through this association becomes an ally rather than an enemy of the teacher. Having the parents of your students supporting you solves many problems with your students and administrators.

As a classroom teacher, I know that I have to deal with all the problems in these children's lives. I know that I am not going to teach students English, history, math, or anything else until I deal with whatever is on their minds. You are not going to be an effective teacher unless you take a holistic approach to teaching.

A Good Teacher Uses "Tough Love" to Control His or Her Students

I will talk about discipline because it is the biggest problem facing inner-city classroom teachers. The average teacher cannot control an inner-city class for several reasons: The teacher is afraid of the students and afraid of the parents of these students. In addition, teachers will say that they do not have the support of their administrators or that their administrators will not "back them up" when they attempt to discipline a child. I am by no means advocating insubordination, but the classroom teacher must be able to control his or her class with or

without the backing of administrators. If this does not happen, no teaching will take place. My approach to classroom control was simple and direct: A child who did not follow the rules in my class had to leave class for that period and could not come back without his or her parents. Parents generally have jobs, other children, or other responsibilities and cannot afford to be running in and out of the school because of one unruly child. As a result, they (the parents) would force the child to behave so they did not have to come in every day. I call that parental involvement, and it works every time.

There are other reasons why there are so many discipline problems in the inner-city schools of the United States. Many of the teachers have no respect for these students. The students are very much aware of this lack of respect, and they show it. In addition, the teachers have very little respect for parents as well, and the parents are equally aware of this lack of respect. An excellent classroom practice is to show respect to your students and their parents. You have to give respect to get respect. It works. Trust me.

When I was in the classroom, I referred to my students as Mr. Smith or Miss Jones (pseudonyms) when I addressed them. When possible, I greeted my students at the door when they walked into the classroom. I stood at the exit door and said good-bye, shook every student's hand, and said "Have a nice day" at the end of class. My students learned early that I respected, loved, and understood them. They also learned early on that I am in control of my classroom.

Teaching the Importance of an Education

I can remember that during my preteen and teen years, I would sit in class daydreaming, wondering why I needed to learn algebra, history, science, and so forth. Many days, I wondered why I needed to be in school at all, particularly since I thought I knew how to read, write, and do arithmetic. Most teachers assume students come to class each day knowing why they are there. In fact, students come to school knowing not much more than that one needs an education to better his or her life. That simply does not tell students enough.

Students have to be taught why they go to school and why they need to study math, social studies, science, and so forth. My approach to this is simple and highly effective. Here are two strategies that could be used to stress the importance of education:

1. Bring professional people into the school to talk about their lives and careers. Students are able to learn from these individuals what they do and what academic preparation is needed to do it. By listening to these professionals and asking questions about all the little nuances of their jobs, not only do students learn what they like or dislike about careers, they also learn what preparation is needed in the academic community to go into a career and excel in that career. In these meetings, students learn why math is important to the engineer or why biology or chemistry is important to the premed student, and so forth.
2. Take students out into the marketplace to visit plants, factories, corporate offices, military bases, and so forth. The reason for this approach is to enable students to see firsthand what goes on in these institutions. In addition to observing what goes on in general, our students are invited to "shadow" certain people to get a firsthand, close-up look at certain careers. Also, it is hoped that students will see others of their own race on these experiences, which provides a collateral benefit that helps build self-esteem.

Once students recognize all the academic subjects needed to get a degree in a particular field, they are more prone to study, stay focused, stay in school, and do all the things necessary to learn, get a diploma or degree, and accomplish whatever goals they set out to accomplish.

Another very important advantage of visiting institutions and having people come to talk about their lives and careers is that students learn how and where these people live. Students learn what these people are able to do with salaries of $50,000 to $100,000 per

year. The point made here is that these students learn what they must do in order to emulate the highly successful people they have observed and heard speak in their classrooms. One speaker or corporate visit per month is sufficient.

All of my adult life I have heard teachers and others talk about why learning does not take place in the classroom (particularly in inner-city classrooms). Let me share with you some of the reasons given by teachers for poor classroom performance: oversized classes, inadequate facilities, no computers, poor teacher salaries, discipline problems, and children not coming to school ready to learn. I feel that every teacher should assume some responsibility for the students' failure to learn. If learning is not taking place, we must look at ourselves first. If we teach students to believe in themselves and to understand the importance of an education, and if we get our classrooms under control, more learning will take place. In addition, the teacher, to be effective, must take a holistic approach in dealing with students in an effort to get his or her message across in the classroom. There is no magic associated with any of these practices. Nor does one have to be a renowned scholar or Ph.D. to implement or employ these practices. It is all really common sense. Think about it.

Student Creativity

Ronald W. Poplau
Shawnee, Kansas

All my life I have been an avowed enemy of what I call "Read and Recite, Tell and Test." I actually cringe at the sight of students copying from textbooks to hand in as a study guide. We know only too well that assignment results in a committee of students who take turns doing busywork.

Although my subject is sociology, this approach or philosophy crosses all disciplines. The key words are still what we learned very early in our own educational careers: "Experience is the best teacher!"